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Engaging Employees in CEO Activism: The Role of Transparent Leadership Communication in Making a Social Impact

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Abstract

With a survey of 600 U.S. employees, this study investigated the effect of transparent leadership communication on employee engagement, from the interpretivist approach, in the context of CEO activism. This study examined employees' perceived psychological needs (i.e., autonomy, competence, and relatedness) as mediators. Results showed that transparent leadership communication is positively associated with employees' psychological needs. In turn, employees' psychological needs mediate the impact of transparent leadership communication on employees' information sharing and activism participation intentions in a CEO activism campaign. Ultimately, this study discussed theoretical and managerial contributions.

Keywords

CEO activism, leadership communication, self-determination theory, employee engagement

As the United States undergoes rapid social changes in recent years, leaders of for-profit businesses started to emerge as advocates on various controversial issues (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). In some events, CEOs intentionally take public stances on social, political, and environmental topics unrelated to their companies' bottom lines and without any evident pretense of raising profits. This phenomenon is coined as

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CEO activism (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). The issues that CEOs advocate concern diverse topics, creating long-lasting and positive ripples in public discourse and exerting policy and/or regulation change. For example, when the executive order temporarily banned travel to the United States from seven predominantly Muslim countries, CEOs from more than 100 U.S. companies co-signed a brief to encourage federal judges to condemn and overturn the executive order (Bensinger & King, 2017). More recently, Zoom CEO Eric Yuan and OpenTable CEO Debby Soo, joining other Asian American chief executives across the nation, stated their commitment to support Asian American communities and fight against anti-Asian racism and violence (Liu, 2021).

Researchers from the academy and industry found that CEO activism and communication can shape public opinion, frame public discourse, influence government policy, and affect consumers' purchase intentions (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018; Larcker et al., 2018; Weber Shandwick & KRC Research, 2018). Nevertheless, how employees react to CEO activism as a company's most critical internal stakeholders remains limitedly examined. Understanding employees' experiences in CEO activism is meaningful to practice and theory building. From the company's profit-making perspective, how employees react to CEO activism will influence their company loyalty and, thus, work performance (Weber Shandwick & KRC Research, 2018). At the societal level, employees are also social citizens. Once mobilized by CEO activism, their forces can cast exponentiated impacts on social, environmental, and political movements (Krishna, 2021). A national survey revealed that 71% of the employees believe they have the power to make a difference in society through actions, such as participation in a demonstration and sharing advocacy information (Weber Shandwick, unitedminds, & KRC Research, 2019).

In investigating CEO activism, one fundamental perspective is how CEOs practice leadership communication in such initiatives. Leadership communication literature indicated that transparent leadership communication is essential in winning employee trust, building positive internal culture, and nurturing favorable relationships (Men & Stacks, 2014; Rawlins, 2009). Thus, the present study aims to (a) test in activism programs how CEO's leadership communication influences employee engagement intention and (b) examine the underlying psychological mechanism that explains the effectiveness of transparent leadership communication. Specifically, this study brings inspiration from interdisciplinary literature and applies the transparent leadership communication construct as the framework for strategic CEO communication with three dimensions (i.e., participation, substantiality, and accountability) (Rawlins, 2009). The mechanism of the influence of transparent leadership communication on employee activism engagement intention is also set forth by three psychological needs as mediators (i.e., autonomy, competence, and relatedness), stemming from self-determination theory (SDT; Deci & Ryan, 2000). Moreover, an interpretivist approach is taken to operationalize employee engagement in response to CEO activism. Two outcome variables are examined: activism participation intention toward the CEO's advocated issue and information sharing intention of the issue. Such operationalization aims to capture employees' behavioral intention and its potential impact on the societal environment and public opinion surrounding the issue being advocated.

We obtained empirical evidence supporting our framework through an online survey among 600 full-time U.S. employees. The results of our study contribute to theory building on the topic of CEO activism, a young yet critical line of research. By embracing those aforementioned multidisciplinary theoretical perspectives, this study aspires to bring novel insights into employees' psychological experiences with CEO activism through transparent leadership communication. The study also aims to offer guidance on how to motivate employee participation in activism activities, facilitating changes in the status-quo of today's society at large.

Literature Review

CEO Activism

When discussing the CEO activism phenomenon, some associated concepts that have illuminated the examination of CEO activism should also be reviewed. They are corporate political advocacy (CPA), corporate social advocacy (CSA), and corporate social responsibility (CSR). Among them, CSR covers the most extensive programs and involves business conducts of fulfilling economic, legal, ethical, and philanthropic responsibilities with the primary goals of reputation and relationship management (Browning et al., 2020; Ji et al., 2021). In addition, CSR does not carry the controversial nature of CSA and CPA when striving for universal support from various stakeholders (Browning et al., 2020). As for corporate advocacy, under which umbrella topic CEO activism prevails, it can transpire in the form of CPA or CSA. CPA refers to the actions that businesses take a public stance on political issues (Ciszek & Logan, 2018). CSA connects to company initiatives of stance-taking on a controversial sociopolitical subject unrelated to its business (Dodd & Supa, 2014). Consolidating insights from previous studies, this study operationalizes CEO activism as CEOs' public stance-taking on social, political, and environmental topics unrelated to their companies' core business and bottom lines[1] (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). Communication research has explicated that organizations can employ public relations strategies to ensure their voices are heard in the public sphere, thereby effectively affecting public policy, organizational actions, and social norms and values (e.g., Ciszek, 2015; De Moya & Bravo, 2016). However, the strategic aspect of CEO advocacy communication and the CEO's leadership role in corporate advocacy are relatively neglected (Dodd & Supa, 2014; Lee & Tao, 2021).

CEOs are the face of their organization and may "literally and symbolically be the organization to stakeholders," externally and internally (Park & Berger, 2004, p. 93). Their use of leadership communication also shapes a company's culture and identity, which, in turn, affects employees' relationships with the company (Men et al., 2020). CEOs have started to realize the impact of their communication on employees' responses to the advocated issue. Thus, they become more committed to public discussions on pressing sociopolitical issues, fostering positive social changes (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018; Lee & Tao, 2021). However, the literature on CEOs' leadership communication in activism remains scarce. In this regard, our study endeavors to fill in the

research gaps mentioned earlier and understand how a CEO, as the agent and executive leader of a company, contributes to activism initiatives through strategic leadership communication.

Studies showed that the impact of CEO activism is particularly prominent among employees (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). For example, CEO activism influences employee loyalty (Weber Shandwick & KRC Research, 2018). Employees are also considered intercessory stakeholders between a company and its external stakeholders and the society the company is situated. With their CEO's leadership communication influence, employees are able to transfer a company's positive intrinsic values to the external environment, advocating and promoting positive economic and social changes (Men et al., 2020). Thereby, this study also focuses on assessing employees' communicative and behavioral engagement intentions as responses to CEO activism.

Employee Engagement as Responses to CEO Activism

Employee engagement is grounded in the conceptual framework of engagement, which is a contested construct commonly conceptualized with two approaches: the *instrumental approach* and the *interpretivist approach* (Johnston & Taylor, 2018; Taylor & Kent, 2014). The instrumental approach theorizes engagement as an individual's affective, cognitive, and behavioral responses to an organization's communication. This approach centers on the direct relational, reputational, and financial outcomes associated with an organization (Hurst & Ihlen, 2018). Meanwhile, the interpretivist approach prioritizes the societal impacts of engagement, which situates an organization within an ecological framework (Ji et al., 2019; Johnston & Taylor, 2018). In this context, through engagement, companies, as societal members, co-construct meaning to address the most critical social issues, generate social capital, and help cultivate a fully functioning society (Johnston & Taylor, 2018; Taylor & Kent, 2014).

Adopting the instrumental approach, previous operationalization of employee engagement is primarily work-state focused, manifested by physical vigor, emotional dedication, and cognitive absorption (Kang & Sung, 2017). Such operationalization is positively associated with the employee–organizational relationship and business outcomes, such as boosting employee work performance and creativity, reducing their absenteeism and burnout, and increasing organizational effectiveness and competitiveness (e.g., Jiang & Luo, 2018; Jiang & Men, 2017; Verčič & Vokić, 2017). However, little communication research has addressed employee engagement beyond the company-centric functionalist approach, fulfilling organizational needs (Jelen-Sanchez, 2017; Lemon, 2019). Among the limited number of CSR studies that theorized employee engagement from the interpretivist approach, employees' CSR engagement was often measured as initiative-participation (e.g., participation in CSR activities and donations), voicing, and information sharing behaviors (e.g., Opoku-Dakwa et al., 2018; Tao & Ji, 2020). These studies transitioned employee engagement from meeting companies' needs to gauge how employees can co-construct meanings with other entities and individuals in a social system and contribute to positive social reformations (Ji et al., 2019; Johnston & Taylor, 2018). The interpretivist approach can expand and

deepen our understanding of employee engagement, rooted in co-creation, togetherness, and openness to change (Lemon, 2019). Therefore, in the current context, employee engagement is operationalized from the interpretivist approach, prioritizing the societal impacts of employee engagement in CEO activism. Specifically, employee engagement is manifested as two outcome variables: employee's activism participation intention and information sharing intention.

Studies outside of communication have provided insights linking CEO activism and employee activism participation (e.g., Briscoe et al., 2014; Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). When employees perceive their CEO's activism as ethical, just, and morally right, they are more inclined to support the cause advocated and defend their CEO's actions externally (Lee & Tao, 2021). This study incorporates employees' activism participation intention as one form of employee engagement to further highlight the societal impact of employee behavior. Specifically, it considers employees' readiness to participate in legal and nonviolent actions (e.g., join advocacy groups, volunteer, make donations) related to the advocated issue (Moskalenko & McCauley, 2009).

Information sharing intention is another indispensable representation of employee engagement in response to CEO activism (Lee & Tao, 2021). It is a reactive behavior of sharing information or opinion about a topic upon others' request or inquiry, such as megaphoning and rebroadcasting (Kim et al., 2010; Lee & Tao, 2021). Specifically, employees megaphoning their organization's CSR accomplishments and problems externally was identified as an essential indicator of employee engagement in responding to the company and CEO prosocial initiatives (Lee & Tao, 2021; Tao & Ji, 2020). Moreover, employees' rebroadcasting of their CEO's advocacy can help form and change the general publics' viewpoint on a sociopolitical issue (Brown et al., 2020). Thereby, investigating information sharing aligns with the interpretivist approach of employee engagement. When employees endeavor to share issue-related messages openly, they are likely to co-construct meanings and create social capital associated with the advocated issue with other entities and individuals.

Employees' Psychological Need Satisfaction and Engagement

Psychological need satisfaction is a fundamental construct in SDT, which posits that human beings have basic needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness (Deci & Ryan, 2000). Particularly, the need for *autonomy* is defined as the need to obtain a sense of ownership of their behavior (Deci & Ryan, 2000). Autonomy is one's willingness to fulfill an assignment without being forced by request (Schultz et al., 2015; Trougakos et al., 2014). The need for *competence* is satisfied when one is provided with resources and feels capable of developing new skills and accomplishing activities and goals (White, 1959). The need for *relatedness* is fulfilled when one feels connected with and cared for by others (Baumeister & Leary, 1995). Baard et al. (2004) advised that the most effective leaders focus on the psychological need satisfaction of their employees. The reason is that when a context is created to help fulfill these needs, individuals' pleasure and possession of activities initiated in such an environment will

increase, leading them to actively seek similar contexts and motivations in the future (Hsieh & Chang, 2016; Pavey et al., 2011).

At the workplace, employees' perceived need satisfaction positively contributes to work- and organizational-oriented outcomes, such as job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and relationship quality with the company (e.g., Men et al., 2020; Tao et al., 2018; Van den Broeck et al., 2016). In addition, satisfying intrinsic psychological needs is vital in leading stakeholder engagement directed at societal changes. Empirical studies supported that when customers can exercise self-determination to support a cause in cause-related marketing programs, their intentions of making a purchase, sharing cause information, and donating are consequently increased (Kull & Heath, 2016; Robinson et al., 2012; Tao & Ji, 2020). Similarly, in CSR campaigns, employees are more likely to commit to long-term contributions to the company's prosocial programs when their psychological needs are satisfied (Tao et al., 2018). Following the above discussions and SDT, this study proposes that similar patterns also exist in the CEO activism context. Specifically, when autonomous need is supported, employees can experience a sense of willingness to participate in activism activities and perpetrate sharing issue-related information (Schultz et al., 2015; Trougakos et al., 2014). Second, when employees find themselves equipped with valuable and necessary resources and skills, they will likely feel confident to partake in various actions and rebroadcast information about the advocated issue (Baard et al., 2004; Deci & Ryan, 2000). Last, employees' sense of attachment and connection with people and communities in need can increase prosocial behaviors and employee activism engagement (Baard et al., 2004; Deci & Ryan, 2000). Synthesizing the discussions together, **H1** is proposed:

> **H1:** Employees' perceived psychological need satisfaction of (a) autonomy, (b) competence, and (c) relatedness is positively associated with their engagement with the issue that their CEO advocates.

Transparent Leadership Communication

Employees regard transparency as a crucial element of effective leadership communication (Men & Stacks, 2014; Rawlins, 2009). Transparent communication comprises three dimensions: participation, accountability, and substantiality (Jiang & Luo, 2018; Rawlins, 2009). *Participation* means involving stakeholders in identifying the information needed to meet their informational needs and make accurate decisions (Jiang & Luo, 2018; Yue et al., 2019). Applying to CEO activism, when a company's CEO delivers advocacy messages with participatory transparency, they should collect feedback from employees and provide detailed information regarding their stance. The employees shall have the necessary information to make informed decisions about the CEO's stance-taking and advocacy behaviors. *Accountability* ensures that the CEO is accountable for their behaviors and words (Jiang & Luo, 2018; Rawlins, 2009). In the current context, *accountability* implies that the CEO provides both sides of a story and be open to criticism or opposition from employees when holding a contrary stance on

the same issue (Yue et al., 2019). Finally, *substantiality* is about providing truthful, substantial, and useful information for relevant parties (Jiang & Luo, 2018; Rawlins, 2009). In CEO activism, communication with substantial transparency signifies that a CEO provides timely, reliable, complete, and relevant information regarding the focal issue instead of merely claiming subjective stance and opinions.

Existing empirical evidence supported the effectiveness of transparent leadership communication in various aspects. Specifically, transparent communication positively affects employees' perceived empowerment at work-related engagement (Jiang & Luo, 2018) and their trust in the employer organization (Jiang & Men, 2017). Transparent communication can also enhance perceived corporate reputation, employee–organizational relationships (Men & Stacks, 2014), employees' openness to change as mediated by organizational trust (Yue et al., 2019), and work-life enrichment (Jiang & Men, 2017).

Based on SDT, this study argues that the CEO's use of transparent communication can also directly affect employees' needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness. First, transparent leadership communication in CEO activism empowers employees to participate in decision-making. When the CEO asks for opinions and feedback from employees regarding the CEO activism initiatives, employees are likely to have a sense of ownership of their behavior, which fulfills their *autonomy* need (Deci & Ryan, 2000) and develops strong feelings of belonging and connectedness, thereby satisfying their *relatedness* need (Baumeister & Leary, 1995; Ryan & Deci, 2000). Moreover, as the CEO provides reliable, relevant, and complete information regarding the advocated issue to practice transparent leadership communication, they truly enable employees to obtain access to resources that may help them in their issue-related activities (White, 1959). Thus, employees' need for *competence* is satisfied. Hence, this study hypothesizes that

> **H2:** Transparent leadership communication on CEO activism is positively associated with employees' perceived psychological need satisfaction on (a) autonomy, (b) competence, and (c) relatedness.

Prior research identified the impact of transparent leadership communication on employee engagement (Jiang & Luo, 2018). However, their operationalized employee engagement behavior primarily adopted the instrumental approach. Meanwhile, some scholars examined employee engagement in initiatives that are not directly related to the company's core business, such as participating in CSR communication, development, and implementation (e.g., Chen & Hung-Baesecke, 2014; Edinger-Schons et al., 2018; Tao & Ji, 2020). A leader's proactive CSR advocacy was found to directly affect employee engagement in corresponding activities when they provided employees with incentives and relevant training (Chen & Hung-Baesecke, 2014). Connecting to CEO activism, when CEOs practice participatory, accountable, and substantial transparency in communicating their sociopolitical opinions, employees are expected to be more likely to engage in activities related to this issue by participating in legal and nonviolent

actions and sharing issue-related information within their networks. Therefore, this study proposes the following:

H3: Transparent leadership communication in CEO activism is positively associated with employee activism engagement by enhancing their (a) activism participation intention and (b) information sharing intention.

Another main prediction of this study is that the individual psychological needs function as the underlying mechanisms explaining the impact of transparent leadership communication on mobilizing employees to support the advocated issues. Environments that help fulfill psychological desires heighten an individual's appreciation and enjoyment induced in these contexts (Tao & Ji, 2020) and, in turn, motivate one to seek comparative contexts to participate in and even initiate activities alike (Hsieh & Chang, 2016). Tao and Ji (2020) discovered that customers' basic psychological needs are satisfied when they are allowed to select their donation beneficiaries. The internalized value of engaging in prosocial activities further motivates customers to donate and spread the word for the nonprofit selection (Tao & Ji, 2020). Gagné (2003) also found that including volunteers in decision-making affects their need for satisfaction, subsequently changing their volunteering intention. Similarly, when employees receive support and encouragement from the company in a CSR campaign, they are more likely to fulfill their three psychological needs, positively affecting their involvement in prosocial behaviors (Tao et al., 2018).

Following the SDT insights, supportive environment provided by transparent leadership communication in a CEO activism campaign can satisfy employees' basic psychological needs. Transparent leadership communication practiced in the CEO activism context contributes to employees' psychological needs of satisfaction. In turn, when employees sense that they have the power, resources, and legitimate relevance to make a difference in the promoted issue, they are more likely to transmit information regarding the issue in their social network. Previous research demonstrated that effective CEO communication can help enhance employee psychological satisfaction regarding employees' self-efficacy, sense of belongingness, and feelings of being emotionally supported (Men et al., 2021). Such enhanced employee satisfaction eventually leads to more favorable relational engagement with the company (Men et al., 2021). The above discussions illuminate the assumption that need satisfaction may also mediate the link between transparent leadership communication in a CEO activism campaign and employee activism engagement. Hence, **H4** is proposed:

H4: The effects of transparent leadership communication on employee activism engagement are mediated by employees' perceived need satisfaction of (a) autonomy, (b) competence, and (c) relatedness.

Method

To test the proposed conceptual model and the hypotheses (see Figure 1), a 15-min online survey was created using Qualtrics and distributed to a panel of employees in the

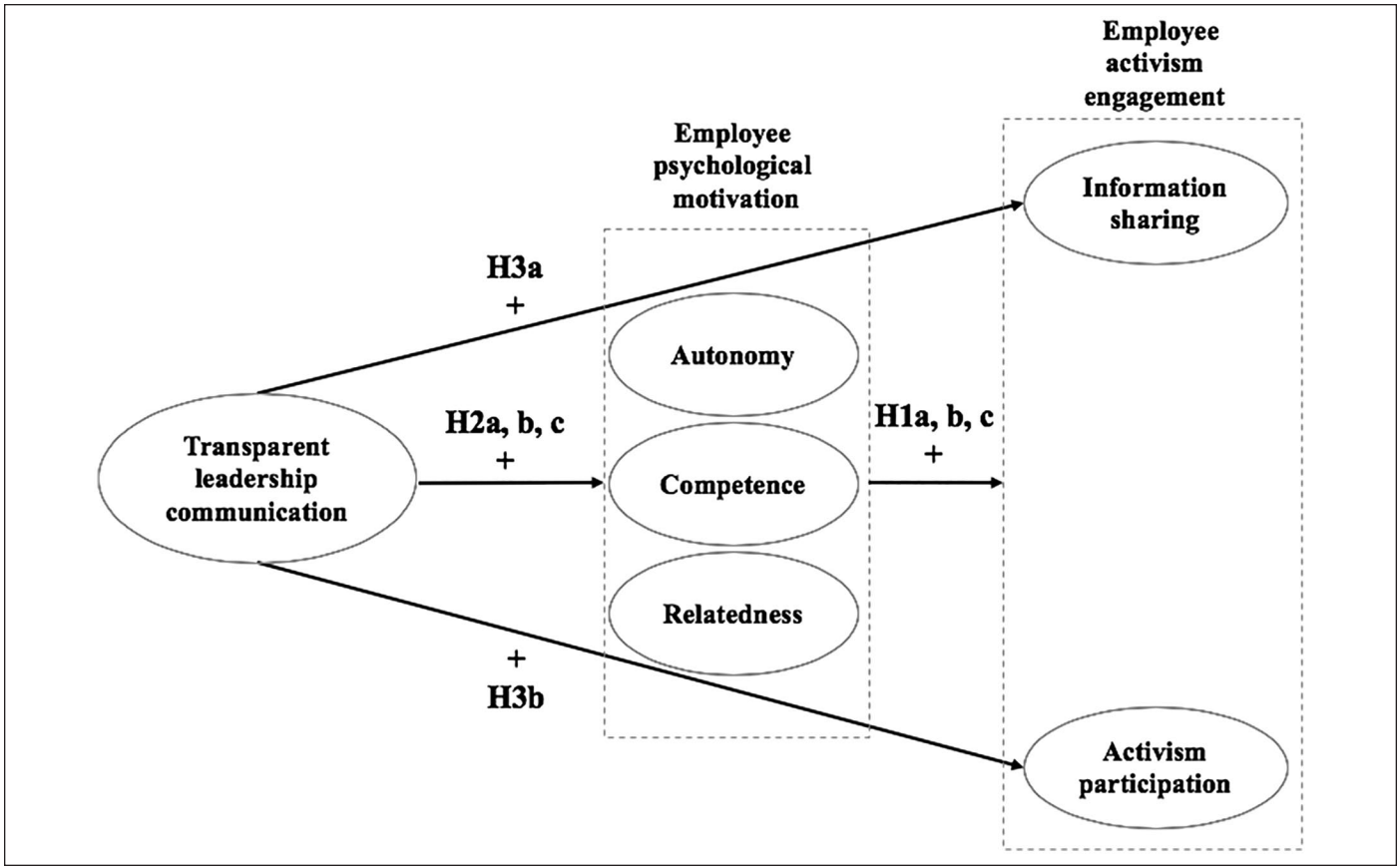


Figure 1. Conceptual model.
Note. Mediation hypothesis **H4(a), (b), (c)**.

United States. A representative employee sample was collected using the quota sampling strategy with varying levels of genders, age groups, income, education, and organization size. A professional sampling service firm, Dynata, assisted the recruiting. Two screening questions were designed at the beginning of the survey to ensure that participants work as full-time employees for a for-profit company and their CEOs advocate for a social or political issue. In addition, participants were instructed to answer three thought-listing questions about the issue, stance, and communication channels of CEO activism. The final sample included 600 employees, with 42.7% males and 51.5% females. The majority of the participants were aged between 25 and 64 years old (80.2%), and more than half were Caucasians (61.2%). Many of them had a bachelor's degree (40.8%). Manufacturing (12.7%), professional, scientific, and technology services (11.8%), and retail trade (10.7%) were the top three industries where participants were employed.

Measures

This study measured all focal constructs (i.e., CEO's transparent leadership communication, employees' psychological motivations, employee's activism participation intention, and information sharing intention) using a seven-point Likert-type scale with 1 being "strongly disagree" and 7 being "strongly agree." All measurement items were adopted from previous literature and modified to fit into the CEO activism context.

To elaborate, CEO's transparent leadership communication was assessed with three dimensions by 16 items adapted from Rawlins (2009). They included participation (e.g., "My CEO asks for feedback from me," $\alpha = .88$), substantiality (e.g., "My CEO provides information that is reliable," $\alpha = .95$), and accountability (e.g., "My CEO presents more than one side of controversial issues.," $\alpha = .95$). The measure of employees' psychological motivation was adapted from Hsieh and Chang (2016) and Robinson et al. (2012). The 14 items comprised three dimensions of autonomy (e.g., "I feel I have control over the issue that my CEO advocates," $\alpha = .96$), competence (e.g., "I am confident that I contribute to the issue that my CEO advocates," $\alpha = .85$), and relatedness (e.g., "I feel related to people who need my help," $\alpha = .95$). The measure of activism participation intention included four items adapted from Moskalenko and McCauley (2009) (e.g., "I would donate money to an organization or group that advocates this issue," $\alpha = .91$). Information sharing intention was assessed using four items developed by Kim et al. (2010) (e.g., "I am willing to talk to someone about this issue if they ask me," $\alpha = .90$). Finally, individual perceived issue involvement was measured as a control variable. The 10-item seven-point bipolar scale was adapted from Bae (2008) (e.g., "unimportant–important," $\alpha = .95$). Table 1 presents the descriptive analysis results.

Results

Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) Analysis

Following Kline (1998), the hypothesized model was analyzed by employing a two-step SEM analysis using the AMOS 25.0 software. In the measurement model, all

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics of Focal Constructs.

Key variables	*M*	*SD*	1	2	3	4	5	6
1. Transparent leadership communication	5.54	1.14	1.00					
2. Autonomy	5.67	1.25	.84**	1.00				
3. Competence	5.45	1.24	.74**	.88**	1.00			
4. Relatedness	5.23	1.25	.71**	.8**	.84**	1.00		
5. Activism participation intention	5.01	1.47	0.68**	.74**	.77**	.8**	1.00	
6. Information sharing intention	5.57	1.07	.59**	.67**	.66**	.67**	.66**	1.00

**Correlation is significant at $p < .001$.

focal variables were treated as latent variables. Among them, transparent leadership communication was treated as a second-order latent variable with three subdimensions. The test of the confirmatory factor analysis model revealed a satisfactory fit to the data: $\chi^2(258) = 545.01$, $p < .001$, root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA) = .043 (90% CI = [.04, .05]), standardized root mean square residual (SRMR) = .03, Tucker–Lewis index (TLI) = .98, and comparative fit index (CFI) = .98. The standardized factor loadings ranged from .75 to .94, suggesting a good fit of the measurement model. The average variance extracted (AVE) and the square root of AVE were also calculated to further evaluate the convergent and discriminant validity for each measure. The results showed that the AVE value ranged from 0.64 to 0.74, surpassing the recommended value of AVE at 0.5 (Hair et al., 2010). For each construct, the composite reliability was larger than AVE. On average, the square root AVE value for each construct was also found to be greater than the corresponding correlation values. Therefore, these results indicate adequate convergent and discriminant validity for each construct. Preliminary analysis was conducted to examine the potential effects of respondents' demographic factors (i.e., age, gender, education level, political stance, issue stance, issue involvement) and company and CEO background variables (i.e., company size, industry, CEO gender) on the focal variables. The results showed that only issue involvement was significantly associated with both the endogenous and exogenous variables. Therefore, issue involvement was included as a control variable.

A second step evaluation of the structural model with issue involvement controlled also yielded satisfactory fit to the data: $\chi^2(277) = 601.37$, $p < .001$, RMSEA = .044 (90% CI = [.04, .05]), SRMR = .03, TLI = .97, and CFI = .98. Thus, the structural model was retained as the final model. A baseline model was compared with the hypothesized model to identify the best-fitting model. Specifically, the proposed mediators, autonomy, competence, and relatedness, were removed from the baseline model. The results showed a significant Chi-square difference between the baseline model and the proposed mediation model, $\Delta\chi^2 = 465.17$ ($p < .001$), thereby supporting the superiority of the hypothesized mediation model.

Hypothesis Testing

H1 proposed that employees' perceived psychological motivations have strong positive associations with their information sharing intention and activism participation intention. Specifically, relatedness demonstrated significant positive effects on information sharing intention ($\beta = .34, p < .001$) and activism participation intention ($\beta = .45, p < .001$). Autonomy was found to be positively associated with information sharing intention ($\beta = .29, p < .01$), and competence was positively affecting activism participation intention ($\beta = .25, p < .01$). However, autonomy had no significant impact on activism participation intention ($\beta = .02, p = .79$). Moreover, competence was not significantly related to information sharing intention ($\beta = .07, p = .45$). Thus, **H1** was partially supported.

H2 and **H3** proposed a positive impact of transparent leadership communication on employees' psychological motivations and activism engagement in the context of CEO activism. The results supported **H2**, indicating that transparent leadership communication plays a prominent role in empowering employees, meeting their psychological needs for autonomy ($\beta = .61, p < .001$), competence ($\beta = .58, p < .001$), and relatedness ($\beta = .56, p < .001$). However, transparent leadership communication was not found to be directly associated with employee activism engagement (information sharing intention, $\beta = .10, p = .15$ and activism participation intention, $\beta = .10, p = .09$). Thus, **H3** was not supported.

To test **H4**, the mediation effects, a bootstrapping procedure ($N = 2{,}000$ samples), was conducted to examine the mediation role of employees' psychological motivations (i.e., autonomy, competence, and relatedness) in the effect of transparent leadership communication on employee activism engagement. The findings demonstrated that relatedness was a significant mediator between transparent leadership communication and information sharing intention, $\beta = .19$, $SE = .05$, $p < .01$ (95% confidence interval [CI] = [.10, .26]) and activism participation intention, $\beta = .25$, $SE = .07$, $p < .01$ (95% CI = [.20, .41]). In addition, employees' need for autonomy mediated the effect of transparent leadership communication on information sharing intention, $\beta = .18$, $SE = .08$, $p < .05$ (95% CI = [.03, .29]). Need for competence was a significant mediator between transparent leadership communication and activism participation intention, $\beta = .15$, $SE = .07$, $p < .05$ (95% CI = [.06, .30]). However, autonomy was not found to be a significant mediator between transparent leadership communication and activism participation intention, $\beta = .02$, $SE = .09$, $p = .87$ (95% CI = [−.13, .16]). Moreover, competence did not successfully mediate the effect from transparent leadership communication to information sharing intention, $\beta = .04$, $SE = .06$, $p = .57$ (95% CI = [−.06, .14]). As such, **H4** was partially supported. Figure 2 displays the hypotheses testing results.

Discussion and Conclusions

As one of the earliest empirical attempts to investigate CEOs' communication in the CEO activism context, this study examined how the use of transparent leadership communication satisfies employees' psychological needs in association with an

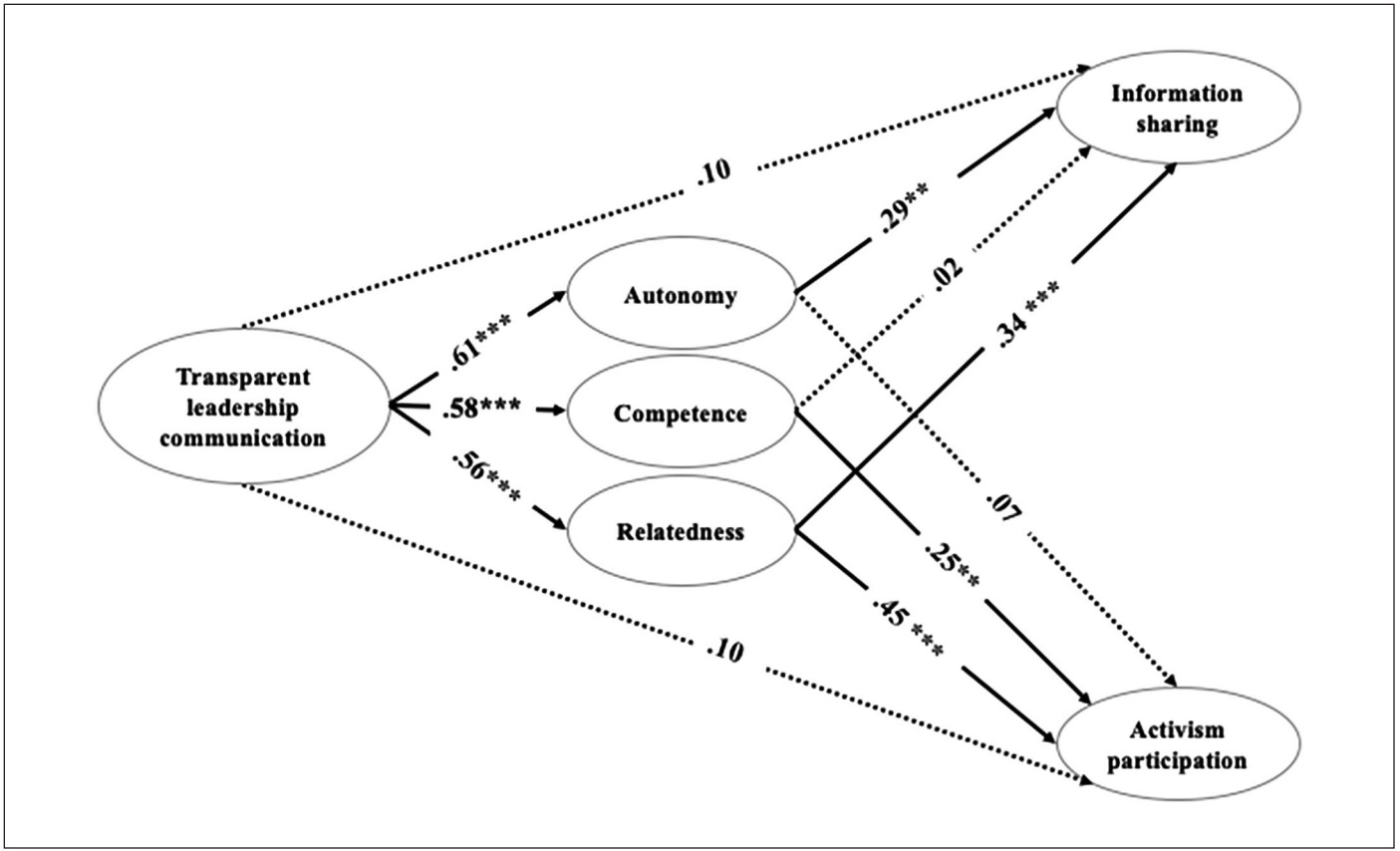


Figure 2. Supported model.

advocated issue and potentially contributes to positive societal changes. Integrating perspectives from psychology literature on the SDT and business communication and marketing literature on leadership communication and corporate advocacy, this study provides innovative and interdisciplinary insights regarding how transparent leadership communication in CEO activism meets employees' psychological needs for satisfaction and motivates their engagement in the forms of participation in activism initiatives and sharing of issue-related information. The study findings also empirically supported the effectiveness of the SDT in explaining the underlying psychological experiences (i.e., needs for autonomy, competence, relatedness) that drive downstream employee engagement in advocacy, mainly focusing on the societal-level impacts. Fundamentally, CEOs' use of transparent leadership communication was found to indirectly influence employee engagement into the issue that CEO advocates when employees' perceived psychological needs are met.

Mediators: Employees' Psychological Needs for Satisfaction

One primary purpose of the study was to explore how executive leaders' use of transparent leadership communication may indirectly influence employees' activism engagement outcomes through psychological needs for satisfaction. The results showed that when CEOs' internal communication is perceived as being participant, sustainable, and accountable, employees' individual psychological needs for autonomy, relatedness, and competence will be met. These satisfied psychological needs, in turn, can motivate employees to engage in different forms of prosocial activities about the issue being advocated by their CEOs.

Among the three psychological needs, relatedness fully mediated the impact of transparent leadership communication on both employees' activism engagement intentions. In comparison, autonomy and competence needs explained the effect between transparent leadership communication and one of the employee activism engagement intentions, respectively. These findings emphasized the indispensable and immediate role of psychological motivation as pinpointed by previous literature (e.g., Kull & Heath, 2016; Tao & Ji, 2020). In addition, the findings are partially consistent with the proposed hypotheses derived from the SDT and the tenets that satisfaction of basic human needs can lead to a significant orientation toward growth and positive social functioning (Deci & Ryan, 2000; Ryan & Deci, 2000).

One important and intriguing finding of this study is the critical role that relatedness needs played in CEO activism. Its meditation effects were consistent in different forms of employee activism engagement. It also exerted the strongest direct impact on the proposed outcomes. Relatedness is the extent to which a person perceives a sense of attachment to the people and environment around them (Pavey et al., 2011). In the context of work performance, connectedness may be considered as one aspect of positive relational and psychological outcomes of SDT (Ryan et al., 2007). However, such connectedness is deemed particularly critical in eliciting prosocial tendencies (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2005). Previous studies demonstrated that compared with autonomy and competence, relatedness is a stronger predictor of perceived connection and attachment, which in turn leads to increased prosocial behaviors, such as volunteering and

donation intentions (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2005; Pavey et al., 2011). Our findings also supported that transparent CEO communication highlighting employees' feelings of relatedness toward others is sufficient to motivate them to act more prosocially.

However, the results did not fully support the mediator's roles of autonomy and competence in the process. This study identified two insignificant linkages between information sharing intention and competence and between activism participation intention and autonomy. We speculate that such insignificant results can possibly be explained by two reasons. One is regarding the nature of the two mediators, and the other concerns the constraints in reaching different forms of activism engagement operationalized in this study. Dahl and Moreau (2007) revealed that, in certain contexts, individuals' autonomy and competence motives are affected by constraints imposed by targeted outcomes. Autonomy reflects individuals' desire to believe that they are the drive and originator of their own actions, underscoring a need for self-governance and self-organized experience (Van den Broeck et al., 2016). In CEO activism and employee engagement, information sharing encompasses a means and need for self-expression and thus resonates better with autonomy than competence. From another aspect, competence reflects individuals' aspiration of mastery over the situation and inherent desire to feel effective in interacting with their surroundings (Van den Broeck et al., 2010, 2016). Behavioral outcomes, such as joining a protest group, volunteering for a rally, and donating money to a cause, are concrete references, which may be more likely to be associated with increased perceptions of competence (Dahl & Moreau, 2007). However, the aforementioned arguments were not empirically tested in the current study as they are not the focal interest. Future research can examine the more comprehensive spectrum of activism engagement (e.g., proactive information seeking and forwarding and reactive activity participation) and how the characteristics of activism engagement outcomes are related to employees' basic psychological needs in the context of CEO activism campaigns.

Taken together, we can conclude that providing psychological support for employees in a CEO activism campaign can be a viable strategy for companies and leaderships to foster employees' activism engagement in the form of information sharing and activism participation intentions. SDT argues that the three psychological needs do not have to be met in order and are of equal importance (Van den Broeck et al., 2010). However, this study, in the context of CEO activism and employee activism engagement, found that they affect employees' information sharing intention and activism participation intention differently. The identified differences echo the argument that competence and autonomy needs are related to individuals' maintenance of intrinsic motivations. That is, people have the need to feel competent and autonomous in carrying out a particular activity, whereas relatedness is inherent to human beings' desire for interpersonal attachment (Gagné & Deci, 2005).

Transparent Leadership Communication and Employee Engagement in CEO Activism

Our results also did not confirm the direct positive association between transparent leadership communication and employee activism engagement. In other words,

employees will not be influenced to participate in issue advocacy or share issue-related information solely based on their CEOs' transparent leadership communication. Simply being exposed to transparent leadership communication cannot directly and immediately trigger employees' interest in taking either participatory or communicative actions. Instead, their decisions largely depend on whether their psychological mechanism is activated by the CEO's transparent leadership communication strategy. If employees find that they do not develop a sense of ownership (i.e., autonomy), feel enabled to accomplish goals (i.e., competence), or have established associations with others in need (i.e., relatedness), then they will feel less motivated to participate in any issue-related activities or share issue-related information to facilitate positive social changes.

Notably, our finding is different from previous studies that found a direct influence of transparent leadership communication on employees' engagement in terms of work performance (e.g., Jiang & Luo, 2018). Such contradictions may be attributed to the nature of CEO activism, which is not directly related to a corporation's bottom line. Meanwhile, in the forms of activism participation intention and information sharing intention, employee activism engagement is not a part of employee performance evaluation, reflecting the instrumental approach of theorizing employee engagement. Instead, employee activism engagement is more concerning a citizen's duties and obligations in exerting positive social changes. Therefore, individual employees are more likely to react to CEO's advocacy messages as individual citizens making independent and personal decisions. When they decide whether to advocate for the issue, they pay attention to their own psychological needs as individual citizens instead of directly being affected by how the CEO talks about it.

Theoretical and Practical Implications

Theoretically, the study contributes to the corporate advocacy and CEO activism literature from an internal and leadership communication perspective. The study showcases the influence of communication transparency featured by information substantiality, participation, and accountability on employee psychological needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness. The findings provide theoretical insights into how transparent leadership communication facilitates societal impact-oriented employee engagement through their activism participation and information sharing of issue-related messages. In addition, this study extends the application of transparent leadership communication strategy into the context of CEO activism and interpretivist employee engagement. As highlighted in the model, the findings also advance the theoretical understanding of executive leaders' public relations functions and their role as essential communication agents connecting internal stakeholders and external social responsibilities. Most importantly, our study shows that, in addition to generating internal and business performance impact, strategic CEO communication can also help produce social capital for the common good.

In addition, this study brings the theoretical insights of SDT to explore the mediating roles of employees' psychological need satisfaction. Their satisfaction concerns

the process through which CEO's transparent leadership communication influences employees' activism engagement in the form of communicative (i.e., information sharing intention) and behavioral (i.e., participation intention) outcomes toward CEO advocacy. The results substantiate employees' need satisfaction as a viable process explanation bridging employees' self-determination to their activism engagement in a CEO-led activism campaign.

This study also offers practical insights. First, organization leaders must recognize that, in this dynamically connected society, they are not only decision-makers and team leaders casting an impact on company-oriented performance. They are also opinion leaders and role models, communicating internally and externally, mobilizing organizational and individual resources to create societal-level values. Toward this purpose, they ought to proactively develop effective communication skills, utilize mass communication and social channels, and convey a balanced, motivating, and relatable story in issue advocacy. When covering critical but controversial sociopolitical issues, journalists can also spotlight CEO activism efforts leveraging the power and words of CEOs as they may effectively direct public discourse and behavior change, as shown in the current study. Our findings also make a compelling case for leaders and communication practitioners to consider employees' psychological needs. That is, employees' perceptions of self-determination in engagement should be enhanced when planning their CEO activism programs. Therefore, in designing CEO's messages to employees and writing news stories to the public audience, public relation practitioners and journalists should highlight individuals' connectedness with the community and group of people under the influence of the advocated issue. Providing a balance between perceived competence and autonomy is also imperative as they can motivate employees to involve in different levels of activism engagement.

Limitations and Future Research Directions

This study also encounters several limitations that should be acknowledged and addressed in future research. First, the current investigation measured transparent leadership communication using employees' self-reported data. Such a method did not assess the actual communication behavior of CEOs in the activism context nor directly reflect the actual impact of CEO activism at the societal level. To overcome these shortcomings, future research could integrate insights from CEOs with qualitative research methods. Future research can also unobtrusively track and map employees' real-time activism engagement, such as employees' digital footprint, under the influence of CEO activism. Moreover, investigators can collect lagged longitudinal data to model employees' engagement data with public opinion narratives and sentiments surrounding the focal issue and associated government policies to demonstrate the impact of CEO activism on social change. Second, this study adopted cross-sectional survey data and SEM analysis to test the proposed conceptual model and hypotheses. However, claiming the causal relationships between predictors and outcome variables is insufficient without a longitudinal or experimental design.

Moreover, to delimit the scope of the study, the model only included transparent leadership communication as a predictor of employees' perceived psychological needs and activism engagement intention. Future studies could also inspect other effective leadership communication styles (e.g., authentic and transformational leadership) and psychological processes (e.g., organization identification and perceived altruism of CEO activism) concerning employee activism engagement. Future investigations can examine other forms of activism engagement (e.g., proactive information seeking, information forwarding, and reactive activity participation). Last, the boundary between whom the CEO embodies in CEO activism, themselves or the company, is not explicit (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). Thus, examining how stakeholders perceive and attribute CEO activism initiatives is a potential future research direction.

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Note

1. Previous researchers contended that identifying if a CEO activism statement solely reflects the CEO's proactive stance in line with their personal viewpoints or their defensive position that needs to be held to achieve the company goals, such as facilitating customer or employee retention, is challenging (Branicki et al., 2020). Regardless of whether a CEO engages in activism on their behalf, owing to individual moral position, or presenting the corporate, aligning with organizational value, such endeavors, is aided (or suppressed) by stakeholders' expectations (Hambrick & Wowak, 2021). Ultimately, stakeholders' evaluations of the CEO can transcend those of the company, where the CEO heads, and vice versa. Therefore, the boundary between whom the CEO embodies in CEO activism, themselves or the company, is not explicit (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). Following previous literature, the current study acknowledges their co-existence and, therefore, does not further distinguish them in our conceptualization.

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